

ANI

MUKESH SAHANI, 42

From partnering with the RJD in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls to storming out of Tejashwi Yadav's press meet on the eve of 2020 state polls, to ultimately aligning with the BJP, this self-proclaimed 'Son of Mallah' has been a mercurial leader. With BJP in 2022 inducting all three MLAs from his party, which goes by the name VIP, Sahani now inhabits a relatively non-VIP zone



ANI

PAPPU YADAV 55

The last time Yadav won a Lok Sabha poll was in 2014 on an RJD ticket. But the party expelled him a year later. Now, Pappu wants to revive old ties, having attended Tejashwi Yadav's Iftar party in April and met Lalu Yadav in May to break the ice. But the RJD has not responded to his overtures so far



ANAND MOHAN SINGH, 69

The release of this criminal-turned-politician in April was touted as a seminal event. Having served over 15 years in jail after his conviction in the 1994 murder of a district magistrate, Anand Mohan has always been a polarising figure, revered by Rajputs, who have considerable presence in eight Lok Sabha seats in the state, but despised by many others. Though his son Chetan Anand is an RJD MLA, the party is yet to assign Anand Mohan a significant role

they know their party will lose in the zero-sum game if they dither. Given such a scenario, why would a party need a bahubali to consolidate votes?"

Despite his words, data has shown how the BJP gains from triangular contests in Bihar. In 2014, when the JD(U) and RJD fought each other, the NDA won 31 of the 40 Lok Sabha seats. But just a year later in the 2015 assembly polls, the united Lalu-Nitish-Congress team ended up slicing away 178 of 243 assembly seats. Well aware that this time it doesn't have the luxury of either a tri-front battle or a formidable JD(U) by its side as it did in 2019, the BJP is reportedly planning to go back to its 2014 strategy of contesting 30 Lok Sabha seats on its own and leaving the remaining 10 for its four allies—Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas), Pashupati Kumar Paras's Rashtriya Lok Janshakti Party, Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular) and Upendra Kushwaha's Rashtriya Lok Janata Dal. Clearly, there's no space for more players, and given that Bihar sends the fourth-highest number of MPs to the Lok Sabha after UP (80), Maharashtra (48) and West Bengal (42), no space for risk either.

As things stand now, while Pappu Yadav has given Congress time till August to decide on his entry into the MGB, Sahani is travelling across the state in a luxury, gold-interior bus, claiming that his Nishad votes can influence the outcome in some 60 Lok Sabha seats in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Jharkhand. Neither MGB nor the NDA have taken note of his *yatra* so far. The last footage of Anand Mohan Singh was of him swinging a lathi on Muharram in his hometown Saharsa. As for Anant Singh's fate, the Bihar police on July 18 lodged a fresh FIR against him after he allegedly attempted a jailbreak and attacked prison staff; his MLA wife Neelam Devi could do little more than take to X (formerly Twitter) and tag Tejashwi Yadav to call the MGB's attention to the alleged violence against Singh in jail. No country for these old men after all, it seems. ■